Safaa El Ouafi

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Dear Dust team,

I've had several careers, but looking back, I realise I've been doing essentially the same thing all along: understanding what people need, building something useful, observing what happens, and finding ways to make it better.

I started in education, designing learning experiences and rebuilding programmes around the needs of learners. At Algolia, I worked on making complex technical knowledge accessible to customers and internal teams. At Alan, I moved further into user research, exploring people's needs, behaviours, and mental models to inform product decisions. Most recently, at Decathlon, I've been researching how designers adopt AI in their actual workflows, while building systems and practices to make research more continuous and accessible across product teams.

Throughout these experiences, one question has kept coming back: How do we make research useful without making everyone dependent on a researcher?

I've built research repositories, introduced continuous discovery rituals, trained product teams, created decision frameworks, and experimented with AI agents that help people frame problems, challenge assumptions, and make better use of existing knowledge.

More recently, that thinking led me to Cassandre, a personal project exploring how established HCI knowledge and AI could help developers identify predictable UX issues before involving human participants. The ambition isn't to automate user research. It's to free researchers to focus on what only humans can help us understand.

Why Dust? Because I've spent an unreasonable amount of time trying to build what Dust already does. And honestly, it's been painful.

Not because I particularly enjoy reinventing the wheel, but because I don't have access to Dust at work. So I've been cobbling together AI assistants, research workflows, and knowledge-sharing tools with whatever my company's systems allow me to use. Which, as it turns out, isn't much. Even the workarounds need workarounds.

The frustrating part is that I know exactly what I want to build, why it would be useful, and who it could help. But getting the tools to talk to each other, accessing the right knowledge, or simply making something usable by my colleagues can become a project in itself.

That's why Dust caught my attention. I don't just understand the problem you're solving intellectually. I've been living it, building around it, and occasionally wanting to scream at my laptop because of it.

And as a researcher, that makes me particularly curious about the gap between what AI makes possible and what people can actually do with it.

I'd love to bring that perspective to Dust: combining hands-on research with the experience of building the systems, habits, and shared capabilities that make research valuable across an organisation.

I've put together a dedicated view of my portfolio for Dust. Rather than organising my work chronologically, it connects projects across education, product research, and AI around the questions I've spent my career trying to answer.

Different jobs. Same obsession.

I'd be delighted to continue that conversation with you.

Best,

Safaa El Ouafi